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Culture (OWC): [Bagisu \(FK13\)](#)

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Bagisu District, Mount Elgon region, Uganda

Section Title(S)

Affines • Kinship Behaviour • Marriage and Incest Regulations

Women in the category of *senge* must be treated with respect; a man treats his father's sister with more circumspection and avoidance than his mother. The father's sister has ritual duties towards her brother's children, at a youth's circumcision and at a girl's marriage. If she is angered by them, she may bewitch them. Men in the category of mother's brother are said to be affectionate and indulgent to their sister's children. A woman must treat her mother's brother with respect and some avoidance, but a man may make himself at home in his mother's brother's home and call on him for assistance at all times. The mother's brother has ritual duties to perform at his sister's son's circumcision and gives him a cow. He receives a goat from the bridewealth of his sister's daughter. The mother's brother has the power to curse his sister's children and his anger is feared more than that of any other relative.

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Relations between grandparents and grandchildren are unrestrained and affectionate. The paternal grandfather is treated with more respect than the maternal grandfather who usually lives in a different village. With the maternal grandparents there is a form of joking which is common: they use the terms for sibling of the same sex and spouse to one another and may demand small gifts in an abrupt, rough manner. This joking may also be indulged with the paternal grandmother; it is rarely used to the paternal grandfather.

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Marriage and Incest Regulations

Sexual relations between members of the same minimal lineage and between a couple who have a common ancestor less than four generations removed

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from themselves are considered incestuous. Adultery with the spouses of members of a person's minimal lineage or with a close relative is classed with incest and arouses the same degree of horror.

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Kinship Regulation Of
Sex

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Extramarital Sex
Relations

Marriage is prohibited with relatives within the forbidden degrees of kinship, with members of the same minimal lineage and with members of the minimal lineages of the mother and maternal grandmother. Sexual relations with a man or woman who is not marriageable but does not fall within the range of close kindred are considered reprehensible but do not require a purificatory sacrifice to cleanse the impurity.

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Regulation Of
Marriage

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Lineages

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Atonement

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Premarital Sex
Relations

A breach of marriage rules is believed to lead to the death of children of the union and, if the kinship between the pair is close, to the death of members of their lineages. If the breach occurs through ignorance a rite "to cut kinship" may be performed. Any breach of marriage prohibitions is more likely to be condoned in this way if the couple are of the same generation than if they are kin of different generations.

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Regulation Of
Marriage

684
Sex And Marital
Offenses

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Life And Death

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Ritual

Polygyny is socially approved and carries prestige, but sororal polygyny is not permitted. If a man's wife dies leaving young children, her sister is thought to be the best person for the widower to marry, since she will care for the children as if they were her own. Should a woman prove barren her father must return the bridewealth or offer one of her sisters as a substitute. If the husband accepts the substitute his first wife must leave him.

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Mode Of Marriage

587
Secondary Marriages

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Polygamy

Widows are inherited by a brother or paternal cousin of the dead man, but they are allowed to return to their natal homes if they prefer. If a widow refuses to be inherited, then some settlement with regard to bridewealth is made, particularly if the woman is still young. The children of an inherited wife are the children of their begetter, but the first son should be named after the dead man. In parts of Bugisu the first child of an inherited wife has a special ritual position and if it is a boy receives special treatment at circumcision.

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Inheritance

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Secondary Marriages

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Affines

Affines are collectively termed *basoni* or *bakwe*. Both these terms derive from 29 words which mean shame or avoidance and the term for bridewealth, *bukwe*, is formed from the same stem. In-laws of the parental generation are addressed by terms of respect and referred to by kinship terms (mother and father) with the addition of the term *musoni*, in-law. Men and women refer to the mother's brother or father's sister by the kinship term used by their spouse. A man calls his wife's sisters by the same term that he uses for her, *umukasi wose*, and she addresses him and his brothers as *umuseza wose*. A man calls his wife's brother and his sister's husband by the reciprocal term *mukwasi* and a woman calls her husband's sister and her brothers' wives *umulamu*, which is also used reciprocally. Co-wives call one another *wangoyo*, 'one of the home', although occasionally the senior wife, the first-married, may be addressed as *mayi*, "mother". Co-wives call each other's children by the terms they use for their own. Finally, the parents of a married couple call one another *masagwa*, a term which is also used between two men who are married to sisters.

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Polygamy

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Kinship Terminology

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